

Toddler Biting Daycare Crisis — Action Checklist

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RULE OUT MEDICAL CAUSES

- ☐ **Rule Out Medical Causes:** Rule out physical causes before building a behavior plan since medical issues like teething, ear infections, and constipation significantly lower your child's capacity to cope with frustration.
- ☐ **Rule Out Medical Causes:** Check for teething symptoms — swollen gums, drooling, nighttime waking, increased chewing — since molars and canines erupt between 18 and 24 months and cause pain that lowers frustration tolerance.
- ☐ **Rule Out Medical Causes:** Ask your pediatrician to check for ear infections since they cause pain that toddlers cannot articulate and frequently follow colds in this age group.
- ☐ **Rule Out Medical Causes:** Assess for constipation — straining, hard pellet stools, withholding, abdominal bloating — since it is widely under-recognized as a trigger for irritability and behavioral outbursts in toddlers.

IDENTIFY YOUR CHILD'S BITE TYPE

- ☐ **Identify Your Child's Bite Type:** Keep a simple log of when and where biting occurs — time, activity, who was present, what happened before — to identify patterns that reveal your child's specific bite trigger.
- ☐ **Identify Your Child's Bite Type:** Look for frustration biting by watching if biting happens when your child is told no, loses a toy, or wants attention from a busy caregiver since this is the most common type.
- ☐ **Identify Your Child's Bite Type:** Observe whether biting happens without clear emotional warning or even when calm since this indicates impulse biting caused by an underdeveloped prefrontal cortex that cannot always apply the brake.
- ☐ **Identify Your Child's Bite Type:** Notice if biting occurs when other children approach, crowd, or physically engage with your child since this may indicate defensive biting triggered by feeling threatened or cornered.

BUILD A COORDINATED RESPONSE

- ☐ **Build a Coordinated Response:** Request a formal meeting with your daycare director to create a written behavior plan that includes consistent responses caregivers will use to prevent mixed signals that reinforce biting.
 - ☐ **Build a Coordinated Response:** Begin teaching your child simple sign language — more, help, stop, all done — since delayed speech is a major driver of communication-based biting in pre-verbal toddlers.
 - ☐ **Build a Coordinated Response:** Respond to biting incidents with calm, brief attention that focuses on the victim rather than the biter to avoid inadvertently reinforcing the behavior through reaction.
 - ☐ **Build a Coordinated Response:** Implement targeted strategies based on your child's specific bite type — sensory-seeking activities for sensory biting, increased attention for attention biting, and predictable routines for impulse biting.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.